

Boston Sunday Globe

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Famed food incubator under fire from within

Infighting, tension mark Commonwealth Kitchen

By Janelle Nanos
GLOBE STAFF

For an entrepreneur whose business was on the cusp of a breakthrough, Nathalie Lecorps felt closer to having a breakdown.

It was December 2023, and the owner of Gourmet Kreyol was having the busiest months of her career. Her food truck and catering business had

won a \$1 million contract to feed Haitian refugees. She'd already hired 32 workers — including some migrants themselves — to roast pork and fry plantains out of Commonwealth Kitchen, the acclaimed food incubator in Dorchester where Lecorps was then based.

Yet Lecorps was so despondent she often sat in her car in Commonwealth Kitchen's parking lot, trying to will herself to walk through its doors.

Instead of feeling like one of Commonwealth Kitchen's success stories, Lecorps felt undermined

KITCHEN, Page A12



VINCENT ALBAN FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE/FILE

“Commonwealth Kitchen is the place where dreams go to die,” said Nathalie Lecorps (center), who had based her business there.

Nursing homes on trading block

As chains flip owners, worries rise on care level

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

Black water from broken pipes seeped through the kitchen floor of a nursing home in Reading for months this summer, with workers scrambling to keep the muck from contaminating serving dishes and food.

At a sister facility in Andover, one of two elevators has not worked for a year, and the ancient air conditioning system struggled to keep up with heat waves. Residents have rarely been served fresh vegetables recently because the food service staff is shrinking and they now don't have enough time to prepare them.

“There's not enough people to pull the job load,” said one food service employee in Reading, who asked to remain anonymous for fear of retaliation. “Everyone is giving their notice and leaving, and others have had their hours cut.”

The shortcomings reflect broader problems at the nursing

NURSING HOMES, Page A13

The average number of arrests by federal immigration authorities in New England has jumped in 2025 to **655 a month**, compared to 192 in 2024.

ICE's hardened machinery

By SEAN COTTER, GIULIA McDONNELL NIETO DEL RIO, AND YOOHYUN JUNG | GLOBE STAFF



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

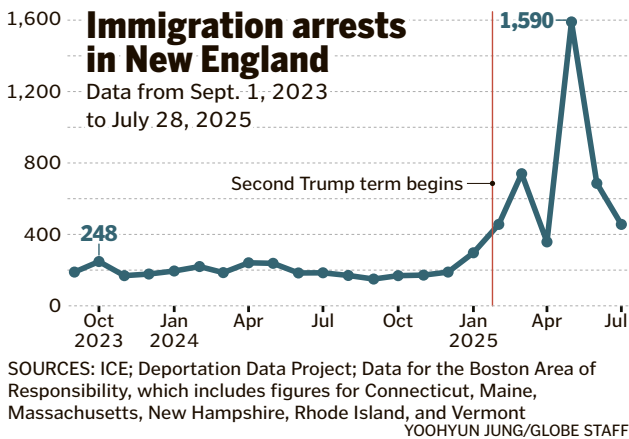
Marta Portillo Vasquez' children Javier and Saul looked out over Boston Harbor. The family is living in fear.

In late August, Marta Portillo Vasquez kept a routine appointment at a federal immigration office in Revere to update her visa application to live in the United States legally after coming here from El Salvador 20 years ago.

Instead, she was abruptly arrested by immigration officers and within a day was whisked off to a detention facility outside Burlington, Vt., before her family could get a judge in the Boston area to intervene.

It took days for her family to confirm where she was being held, all the while pleading with officials to keep her within reach. They spent the week living in fear she could be transferred anywhere across the country.

“It's been really worrying. Anxiety. Sleepless nights,” her eldest son, Saul, 32, said in an interview last week. “Now it's at a crucial point again where she's going to be moved again, and we don't know where. . . . We won't have a clue at all.”



They finally won temporary relief when late Friday a judge in Vermont ruled that for the time being, Portillo Vasquez cannot be moved out of state.

Her swift arrest and transfer, and her family's struggle to keep up with it, underscore an emerging truth about the Trump administration's immigration crackdown: in New England, which had few facilities for enforcement and even less political interest in building one, the federal dragnet has in

ICE, Page A8

With Suffolk sheriff, an echo of past problems

By Danny McDonald
and Andrew Ryan
GLOBE STAFF

A governor appoints a sheriff with zero experience in law enforcement. Soon enough, the office is mired in allegations of malfeasance.

It's déjà vu in Suffolk County.

Two decades ago, the then-sheriff of Suffolk County, Richard J. Rouse, resigned after the Globe Spotlight Team and the FBI revealed physical abuse by his guards, runaway nepotism in his hiring, and chronic mismanagement at his office.

This time, it's Steven W. Tompkins who is accused of wrongdoing, pleading not guilty to two charges of extortion and announcing he would step away while the federal case is ongoing.

Both Rouse and Tompkins were known more for their political pedigrees than for relevant work experience. Rouse was a popular state representa-

SHERIFF, Page B10

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Freshman mixer

Sunday: Cooler, rain ending.
High: 65-70. Low: 55-60.

Monday: Partly sunny.
Complete report, **C24**.
Obituaries, **C22-23**.

Despite a late start, a ride on Amtrak's NextGen Acela is a huge improvement, says travel writer Christopher Muth-er. **SundayTravel, N11.**

These contemporary homes take natural living to a new level — they let the outside in. See the Your Home edition of the **Globe Magazine**.

The NFL season is finally here and New England waits breathlessly for the beginning of the Mike Vrabel era, writes Dan Shaughnessy. **Sports, C1.**

A visit to the time of Shakespeare

Stephen Greenblatt's “Dark Renaissance” conjures the life and times of Christopher Marlowe. **Books, N9.**



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